Presented by Sharon Lee

Memory Cafe: building a more sustainable funding model

National Comedy Center | Funding and AI usage strategy

Strategic Vision

Establishing A Clear Direction For Growth

NCC's best strategic decision moving forward is to center Memory Cafe as a caregiver-support program that provides social connection to appeal to funding groups supporting healthcare and elderly groups.

Strong unmet funding opportunity

NCC x Memory Cafe haven't utilized funding from healthcare/wellness orgs

Not just a "comedy program"

Memory Cafe's greatest distinguishable aspect is that it is a comedy program; however it is also a space for caregiver connection, support for those with dementia

Capacity doesn't have to be a constraint

By utilizing AI, we can efficiently identify high-fit funding prospects to establish a process maintainable by Rochelle

Current approaches & future possibilities

Current

$30k grant Wilson Foundation

No systematic health/wellness foundations contribution as of now

CFO Rochelle carries most of development responsibilities

Proven program, limited funding infastructure

Comparing organizations

SPARK!
similarity: culture, memory loss organization
difference: direct demonstration that arts can tangibly serve those experiencing memory loss (and caregivers)

CaringKind
similarity: caregiver/dementia patient population
difference: values direct demonstration of how experiences affects the patient and those beyond the patient

What to take away

What sets Memory Cafe apart?
Comedy, culture, interactive museum experience

More development could happen in...
Health-org fundraising, diversified Memory Cafe funding

AI & NCC

AI in the sector

1. Research
   Prospect searching/identification
   Grant history research/summarization
   Funding pattern identification
2. Drafts
   First draft of donor emails
   Personalizing outreach methods
3. Workflow support
   Automation of tasks
   Preparation of relevant materials

What AI does **NOT** replace

- Determination of how well a funder fits
- Categorizing the emotional impact of given organization
- Donor framing

NCC's usage of AI

Limited AI usage or AI help in fundraising

Practical Application:
AI usage in

1. Research
   Grants, Donor, general fundraising
2. Preparation
   Reaching out to orgnizations,
   company meetings to discuss fundraising
3. First Drafts
   Drafting donor emails, outreach emails to possible donors

Foundation Partnerships

Health Foundation for Western & Central New York

First Priority

- older adults/caregiver target audience
- Western New York geography
- pre-existing grant activity for initiatives similar to Memory Cafe
- $25k-100k grant

Memory Cafe can be framed as a community-based social-connection program for those living with dementia and their affected families.

The Humana Foundation

Second priority

- emotional health for seniors
- battling loneliness and loss of social connection
- supports community-based programming

Memory Cafe can be framed as a program that gives older adults living with dementia and their respective caregivers an emotionally nourishing community event that increases social connection.

The John A. Hartford Foundation

Third Priority

- healthy aging & family caregivers
- age-friendly/community-based initiatives
- have given grants to organizations in rural areas similar to NCC/Memory Cafe

Memory Cafe is a community-based social connection initiative that targets populations affected by dementia. It presents comedy as a cultural experience rather than a source of entertainment.

Implementation Plan

Health Foundation for Western & Central New York

Contact Program officer/Grant manager

Keywords: Social connection, caregivers, cognitive nourishment

Showing that comedy can be a cultural experience, it emphasizes the positive emotional experience that memory Cafe offers. Families get to connect and create new joyful memories together.

The Humana Foundation

Contact program manager, check seasonal grant eligibility

Keywords: Senior emotional wellbeing, social connection

By framing the impact as a cultural one rather than clinical, comedy can be seen as the catalyst for moments of joy, laughter, and connection between populations that may struggle to find these moments in their day to day lives. This would fit the foundation's focus on reducing senior isolation.

The John A. Hartford Foundation

Contact program manager after determing a strategic fit of Memory Cafe with the foundation

Keywords: community-based connection, caregiver support

Framing the Memory Cafe in this way bridges a gap of connection and tangible, emotional experience that is shared by both caregivers and patients.

Donor Example

The most probable donor is one that has personally experienced the tangible affects of Memory Cafe.

Sarah

- An adult caregiver for her mother who is experiencing dementia
- Regularly visit Memory Cafe with her mother and carries significant emotional weight regarding her mother's condition and the positive impact that Memory Cafe has had on it

Carries INTO Memory Cafe

- emotional/physical fatigue
- concern for her mother's emotional/physical health



Carries OUT of Memory Cafe

- many moments of shared joy
- lessened loneliness

The Ask

- a personalized follow-up email after Memory Cafe attendance
- Initial amount: something accessible like $100-200, funding her experience not necessarily the NCC company
- "Helping another family experience the strength of Memory Cafe like yours has."

AI personalized for Rochelle & NCC

Personalized AI workflow: research → verification → outreach

Research

Based on preset criteria, AI generates **potential funders**

Ranks the funders in terms of

- mission
- geography
- grant size
- prior funding
- etc.

Verification

Rochelle verifies primary sources.

Given the AI generated

- Prospect brief
- Contact Summary
- Funder-specific mission

Rochelle reviews

- Is this a good fit?
- Is this the right person?
- Is the mission tailored to the right foundation?

Human judgement is essential

Outreach

AI is helpful with:
Research synthesis/summarization, Comparison, repetitive research

Human judgement is required for:
Strategizing relationships, genuine emotional connection, general accuracy

Introduce a 30-60 minute automated AI workflow that saves Rochelle time when researching each prospect.

Next Steps for Rochelle & NCC

First Step

Actively PURSUE the best fit foundation

- Strong mission fit, geographic fit, realistic-size fit
- relevant funding experience

PREPARE

- program description
- outcome/attendance
- budgest and outreach strategy
- value proposition that resonates with Health Foundation for NY

AI USAGE

- prospect preparation and program information drafting

Second Step

BUILD a pathway for individual donors

- room for natural funding with those who are already familiar with Memory Cafe
- diversify funding

PREPARE

- personalized post-event follow up
- automated donor messages

AI USAGE

- automating personalized follow-up message system

Third Step

CREATE a repeatable funding loop

- a successful pitch can be replicated to continue funding/growth

PREPARE

- prospect research automater
- template for grant/foundation research
- general calendar/schedule for outreach

AI USAGE

- constantly updating research system

Continuing On

<u>In the next 30 days</u>
Contact The Health Foundation of NY and prepare a personalized Memory Cafe case statement .

Prepared Already

Prospective foundation research
Individual donor example and reasoning
AI workflow diagram/logic

Continue to work on

What specific outcomes will Memory Cafe measure?
Which health-sector relationships can Memory Cafe look into?
Tangible evidence regarding Memory Cafe's attendance, stories/testimonials, caregiver experience that can be used to support funding

Extern x PwC & National Comedy Center

Thank You

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